

Advocacy — Methods, Record, and a Trimtab Alternative

A reference for makers of campaigns, written to be given away

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Written to be given away. This document is a reference for people about to make advocacy: it defines advocacy, surveys the methods the field has used, records what succeeded and what failed and at what cost, and closes with an alternative — one author's proposed method, a trimtab method, offered to be used, changed, or discarded. The licence permits all of that. Figures are cited to their sources in §10. This document was developed with assistance from Claude (Anthropic PBC). All strategic decisions and commitments are those of the author.

Introduction

This reference exists so that a room full of people about to invent advocacy campaigns can stand on the field's whole record instead of its habits. It defines the craft (§1), lays out the methods in use (§2), and walks the record of what succeeded and what failed, with the costs attached (§3–§5) — because the costs are the least-told part of the story and the most instructive. It then opens the psychology beneath the record — the named, studied mechanisms of why persuasion fails and demonstration works — and examines the two great carriers, art and marketing. It names the adversary's method rather than politely omitting it (§6), and then offers one alternative built from what the record teaches (§7) — its four commitments, the design model beneath them, three design rules, and the instruments that make its falsifiability real — with its limits stated (§8) and an invitation attached (§9). Every figure traces to a named source (§10).

How to use it: read your own idea against §5's pattern and §7's five-part test the way a hostile reader would, before one does. The document is a whetstone, not a doctrine — §9 says what to do with it.

Summary

Advocacy has three modes: speaking for, speaking to, and showing. The record is unsentimental about which works. The great failures — a billion-dollar campaign that may have backfired, the most viral video of its era achieving nothing — share four properties: episodic, extractive, persuasive, unfalsifiable. The lasting successes — decades-long, cheap per point, owned by the people shown — are durational, membered, demonstrative, and measured. The platform era amplified this split: the feed rewards the burst, and movements grew faster, larger, and shallower. The dividing line is not the budget but the unit shared: a message decays; a membership act accumulates.

The adversary's method, the firehose, manufactures futility rather than belief — and its structural weakness is that it can fake any single story but cannot fake the same verifiable place revisited over years. From this the alternative in §7 follows: duration as evidence, membership not extraction, demonstration not persuasion, falsifiability in the room — four commitments, load-bearing together, with a five-part test for building an instance of your own. The method is slow, bounded by consent, and wrong for crisis response; those limits are accepted and stated. The psychology beneath all of this is named and studied — reactance, dissonance, contact, learned helplessness — and the middle of the document walks it, along with the two great carriers: art is demonstration's native language, marketing its craft of legibility — both carriers, neither a method, and the strongest creative advocacy is art the audience makes itself.

Beneath the method sits a design model, borrowed as structure from the physics of driven oscillation and as ethic from a convergence of older traditions, and bounded explicitly by what does not transfer: the advocate's task is tuning, not transmission. Find the audience's frequency rather than broadcasting your own; place small inputs in phase; repeat coherently; choose depth or breadth and say which; expect to be changed. The model supplies what the four commitments left implicit — three design rules (selectivity named, one drop point in sequence, feedback that can alter the work) and a measurement architecture: instruments matched to the chosen selectivity, a baseline before the first input, benchmark curves taken from the record rather than invented, nulls published. It reads the firehose as a damping strategy, against which volume is the wrong physics and coherence over time the one thing that still accumulates. The whole document is licensed to be taken, changed, and outgrown.

1. What advocacy is

From the Latin *advocare* — to call to one's aid. An advocate is one who speaks for another, or for a cause, toward those with the power to act.

A working definition: **advocacy is the organised attempt to change what people believe, feel, or do about something, on behalf of someone or something that cannot make that change alone.**

Three modes hide inside the definition, and most methods mix them without noticing:

- **Speaking for** — representation. Giving voice to those unheard: testimony, witness, legal advocacy.
- **Speaking to** — persuasion. Arguments, appeals, framing, campaigns aimed at an audience's beliefs.
- **Showing** — demonstration. Building or revealing the thing itself and letting the audience conclude.

Adjacent forms, worth separating: **propaganda** disregards truth in service of the sponsor; **marketing** serves a

transaction; **activism** is the broader category of acting for change, of which advocacy is the communicative part. The boundary that matters most in wartime: advocacy that disregards truth has become propaganda, whatever it calls itself.

The practice is old. The first recorded collective action for redress is the Deir el-Medina strike of about 1157 BC — tomb artisans sitting at the temples until overdue grain rations were paid, and winning. Rome's secessio plebis of 494 BC won the tribunate by mass withdrawal from the city — refusal of participation as leverage. Advocacy is not a modern invention; only its industrialisation is.

2. The methods — a short taxonomy

The field's main approaches, each with its core mechanism:

- **Rebuttal and fact-checking.** Correct the false claim. Mechanism: accuracy. Known weakness: repeating a claim to refute it strengthens its familiarity.
- **Framing and narrative change.** Change the frame, not the facts (Lakoff; FrameWorks). Mechanism: repetition installs frames. Weakness: decade-scale, infrastructure-heavy.
- **Deep canvassing.** One non-judgmental conversation in which the listener talks and exchanges a personal story (Broockman and Kalla). The strongest measured durable attitude shift in the literature. Weakness: one-to-one economics.
- **Solutions journalism.** Report responses, not only problems. Measured effect: higher reader efficacy, less news avoidance.
- **Social norms.** Show that the desired behaviour is common (Cialdini). Weakness: showing a bad behaviour as common normalises it — several campaigns backfired here.
- **Moral reframing.** Argue in the audience's own moral vocabulary, not the speaker's (Feinberg and Willer).
- **Hope-based communications.** Lead with the vision, not the violation — the human-rights field's own correction after outrage stopped working.
- **Entertainment-education.** Serialized fiction carrying attitude change (radio dramas; telenovelas). Works — and is fiction, with everything that costs in trust.
- **Testimony and witness.** Documented suffering carried to those who can act (Amnesty model). Risk: extraction — the subject becomes material.
- **Counter-mapping and crisis-mapping.** Change what the map shows (Ushahidi lineage); or change the map's unit entirely.
- **Twinning and sponsorship.** Durable relationships as the medium: sister cities, community refugee sponsorship — participation itself converts attitudes over years.
- **Strategic litigation.** Change the rule rather than the attitude: the NAACP's twenty-year path to *Brown v. Board*; Urgenda (2019), where the Dutch Supreme Court ordered the state to cut emissions 25%. Durational, low-membered, decisive where a rights framework exists to invoke.
- **Insider advocacy — lobbying.** The field's biggest spend: access, drafting, relationships (US federal lobbying alone exceeds \$4 billion a year). Effective, opaque, access-priced — the least membered method in existence, and the one money likes best.
- **Community organizing.** Build power through relational infrastructure and win by negotiation (Alinsky; the IAF tradition): the outcome is a seat at the table, not an attitude change.
- **Economic pressure — boycott, divestment, sanctions.** Make complicity costly and refusal cheap; participation itself is the message. Slow, coercive, membered at mass scale; decisive mainly when it reaches finance rather than trade. Refusal alone is half a method — the strongest campaigns welded it to a constructive programme: Gandhi's khadi was a no to Manchester and a visible yes to an existing Indian capacity, in one garment. The full instrument set has four verbs: refusal (boycott), exit (divestment), voice (shareholder activism), and coordinated entry (the buycott — weaponised at GameStop, \$4).
- **Art and cultural work.** Image, theatre, music, and made object as the carrier: from the Brookes diagram to the AIDS quilt. Art is demonstration's native language — it shows, and the viewer finishes — and it is unit-agnostic: the same craft has served memorials and tyrannies. See the art and marketing section.
- **Demonstration and prefigurative politics.** Build the alternative and let it argue: Fuller — a new model that makes the existing model obsolete.
- **Platform and influencer advocacy.** Renting industrialised attention and parasocial trust in the creator economy. Not a method but an amplifier with an episodic bias: the algorithm rewards the burst. It succeeds when the shared unit is a membership act performed by the sharer, and decays when the unit is a message (§5).
- **Social marketing and brand activism.** The advertising discipline applied to causes (Kotler and Zaltman, 1971): audience research, message testing, distinctive assets, consistency — and, lately, brands taking public stances. The techniques transfer; the transaction logic does not. See the art and marketing section.
- **Satire and culture jamming.** Adversarial humour; can topple a regime (Otpor) and cannot be gentle.

- **The firehose.** The adversary's method — see §6. Named here because a taxonomy that omits it explains nothing about the present information environment.
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3. The record — successes, with costs

British abolition (1787-1833). The founding modern campaign — twelve men in a London print shop who invented most of the toolkit within five years: Clarkson's evidence-gathering from sailors and ships' doctors (the first investigative advocacy), the Brookes slave-ship diagram (demonstration by image, no caption needed), Wedgwood's kneeling-figure medallion (membership made wearable), Equiano's first-person testimony, mass petitions at unprecedented scale, and the 1791-92 sugar boycott — some 300,000 households abstaining, run substantially by women, for whom the sugar bowl was the one political instrument available. Twenty years to abolish the trade, forty-six to end slavery in the empire — and the record's most sobering cost line: emancipation was purchased with £20 million in compensation paid to the slaveholders, financed by a loan not fully retired until 2015. Even the founding success paid its victory in the currency of the powerful.

MADD (US, 1980-). Survivor-led norms change plus legislation; drunk-driving deaths roughly halved from about 22,000 in 1980 to about 10,500 by 2018. Grassroots chapter economics — likely the cheapest large-scale attitude reversal on record. The shown people owned the showing. And an honest coda: the halving has partly reversed — about 13,500 alcohol-involved deaths in 2022, a third above 2019, as pandemic-era enforcement and cultural pressure slackened. Norms are maintained, not achieved; duration is a practice, not a trophy.

The truth campaign (US, 2000-). The best-measured success in advocacy. About \$324 million spent 2000-2002; a published estimate attributes 22% of the 1999-2002 decline in youth smoking directly to it; roughly \$1.9 billion in medical costs averted — the campaign recouped its cost, at about \$544 per averted adolescent smoker. Register: it never told teens to obey; it exposed industry manipulation and let teens complete the meaning as rebellion.

Marriage equality (US, 1990s-2015). Decades and hundreds of millions across the movement. Rights-arguments lost ballot measures for years; attitudes moved when the abstract became a visible neighbour — demonstration succeeding where persuasion failed on the same question.

Jubilee 2000 (global). Over \$100 billion of poor-country debt cancelled, from a church-basement coalition: one concrete ask, one date, carried by existing congregational networks rather than bought reach.

ALS Ice Bucket Challenge (2014). \$115 million in eight weeks at near-zero campaign cost; \$1 million of it funded the gene-sequencing project that identified NEK1. Viral success came here from the audience performing the act themselves — the share was the act.

#MeToo (2017-). The clearest social-media success, and its anatomy explains it: every post was the poster's own story, self-published, under their own name and at their own risk — testimony at scale with zero extraction. The shown people were the showers. It produced real institutional outcomes: prosecutions, NDA reform, state laws. The hashtag was a membership act, not a message.

Stolpersteine (Germany, 1992-). The 100,000th stone laid in May 2023; stones across dozens of European countries; each financed by sponsorship at 120 euros, each biography researched and each family asked for consent before a stone is made. A name, dates, a place — "Here lived" — no narrator. The largest decentralised memorial in the world, at the price of a dinner per point. Durational, membered, demonstrative, verified — three decades before this document names those words.

The AIDS Memorial Quilt (US, 1987-). Begun from placards taped to a federal building; 1,920 panels on the National Mall in 1987, about 50,000 today carrying more than 110,000 names — 54 tons, the largest community art work in the world, nominated for a Nobel Peace Prize. Each panel is three by six feet, the size of a grave, and is made by the dead person's own people — for many, the only funeral that stigma allowed. The 1996 full display drew 1.2 million visitors. Read against §7: durational, membered to the stitch, demonstrative — a name and a life, no caption arguing anything — and verified, because love does not fabricate its dead. Art as advocacy at its fullest: the memorial is the campaign, and the making of it was the membership.

Green Belt Movement (Kenya, 1977-). From seven seedlings in 1977 to more than 51 million trees and 30,000 women trained in income-generating trades; survived a decade of state repression; Nobel Peace Prize 2004. The advocacy was the growing: each tree simultaneously proof, income, soil, and membership. Among the lowest cost-per-outcome ratios in the field's history.

Treatment Action Campaign (South Africa, 1998-). Forced a denialist government to provide HIV treatment. Members wore their stigmatised status openly — the shown people were the movement — combined with litigation.

Anti-apartheid boycott and divestment (1959-1991). Among the largest membered campaigns in history by participation: three decades of consumer refusal, the Barclays withdrawal after its share of new student accounts collapsed, and the sports and cultural boycott — which cost almost nothing and cut deepest, telling white South Africa in its own most-valued register that it had become a pariah. Recorded with the multi-causal caveat: internal mass resistance and the 1985 refusal of banks to roll over South Africa's loans outweighed three decades of trade measures. The boycott set the climate; the townships and finance forced the end.

Engine No. 1 (US, 2021). The financial trimtab: a fund holding about 0.02% of ExxonMobil won three board seats with a proxy campaign reported at roughly \$12.5 million — not by fighting the ship but by persuading the few giant index holders whose votes turn it. Among the smallest lever-to-outcome ratios in the modern record.

Samsø (Denmark, 1997-). An island that made itself renewable-energy self-sufficient in a decade, islanders owning turbine shares. It never argued the transition was possible; it became the place you point to.

German anti-nuclear movement (1970s-2023). Fifty years from village occupation to legal phaseout; the smiling-sun logo was Danish (OOA, 1975) and spread through carrier networks, never bought.

Gandhi's salt march (1930); Madres de Plaza de Mayo (Argentina, 1977-); Chipko (India, 1970s). The archetypes: demonstrating an existing capacity rather than petitioning against a law; walking the same circle weekly under a dictatorship until the dictatorship ended; bodies around trees as physical fact. Durational, membered, largely wordless.

Otpor (Serbia, 1998-2000). Helped bring down Milošević with humour, dilemma actions, and easy visible membership — the strikes and the security services' defection did the final work. Recorded as a success — and as a mode (adversarial satire) that does not transfer to every context; what transfers is the membership mechanics.

NAFO (2022-). Decentralised, self-funded, crowd-organised support for Ukraine: the fella avatar as a membership token earned by donating, millions raised, and a real degradation of Russian official accounts' ability to operate unmocked. A success in the same adversarial- satirical mode as Otpor, with the same caveat — the membership mechanics transfer; the register does not transfer everywhere.

4. The record — failures, with costs

Kony 2012. The most viral video of its era — over 100 million views in under a week — raised about \$30 million; funds were exhausted within roughly two years, the stated objective was never achieved, the sequel drew under 1% of the original audience, and the organisation announced its own closure. Episodic, extractive (the African backlash was about exactly this), persuasive, and unfalsifiable until reality falsified it.

US National Youth Anti-Drug Media Campaign (1998-2006). Over \$1.4 billion appropriated. The government's own audit found credible evidence the campaign was not effective at reducing youth drug use — and the core evaluation found possible delayed unfavourable effects: more ad exposure predicting weaker anti-drug norms and later initiation. Pure persuasion at maximum budget, with a plausible norms backfire: saturation taught teens the behaviour was common.

D.A.R.E. (classic curriculum). Hundreds of millions per year across US localities for two decades; meta-analyses repeatedly found effects near zero. Authority-figure persuasion — the register the truth campaign succeeded by inverting. It survived its own null evaluations for years because nothing in its design could fail visibly.

Scared Straight. Systematic reviews found participants more likely to offend than controls — an iatrogenic program whose cost-benefit runs steeply negative once induced crime is counted. Fear-based demonstration aimed at the audience: demonstration weaponised as persuasion.

Remain (UK, 2016). Establishment backing, a government mailing to every household, and a fear-forward economic case against a simple affirmative frame. Lost. Threat framing against a side offering agency and identity is a losing register.

Band Aid / Live Aid (1985). A fundraising success and a mental-map failure: it deposited a picture of a helpless, undifferentiated continent that African critics have spent forty years contesting. The standing warning: a sympathy campaign built on extracted suffering works short-term and builds the wrong permanent map — pity hardens into futility.

Fridays for Future. Enormous salience gains and weekly repetition — but persuasive in register, an ask in every frame, and salience decayed with polarisation. Repetition of an argument fatigues; repetition of a demonstration accumulates.

#BringBackOurGirls (2014). Global virality reaching the White House — and most of the Chibok girls remained captive for years, with dozens unaccounted for a decade later. Virality is not leverage when the target does not care about the audience: the 1933 lesson at fibre-optic speed.

GameStop (2021). The inverse of a boycott: coordinated buying as a weapon. A short-seller lost 53% in a month and later closed; then the platform halted buying mid-surge and the movement collapsed within two weeks. Three honest readings at once: a new form (coordinated market entry); membership at its most extreme (own money, own risk, identity proven by willingness to lose); and a failed advocacy campaign — motives commingled with profit handed every hostile reader the permanent rebuttal, late buyers absorbed the losses, and no structural reform followed. Its one durable product was accidental: the halt itself demonstrated, live, whose side the market's plumbing sits on — a legibility event no argument could have staged.

5. What the record teaches

The failures share four properties: they are **episodic** (a burst, then nothing), **extractive** (subjects as material), **persuasive** (the meaning is asserted, not completed by the audience), and **unfalsifiable** (no stated failure condition, so budgets outlive evidence). They are also the most expensive per unit of nothing: \$1.4 billion for a possible backfire; \$30 million for a viral null.

The successes are **durational** (decades: MADD, marriage equality, Stolpersteine, Green Belt, the Madres), or **membered** (the shown people own the showing: MADD, TAC, Ice Bucket, Jubilee's congregations, Stolperstein sponsors), or **demonstrative** (truth's exposure, visible households, an island, a tree), or **measured** (truth's attribution study). One pattern in the money: with one exception, the deepest successes needed no media buy at all. The exception maps the rule — truth bought reach for a demonstration unit and measured itself, and worked; the billion-dollar nulls bought reach for a message. The purchase is not the variable. The unit is.

The platform pattern now has measurement. The 2020 racial justice wave produced the largest protests in US history; Pew's series shows support at 67% in June 2020, 55% by September, and 51% by 2023 — a spike and reversion at algorithmic speed. The amplifier is real and its bias is episodic: it delivers salience and cannot deliver duration. Hand it a message and you get the curve; hand it a membership act — my story, my drenching, my abstained sugar — and each share is itself a small demonstration performed by the sharer, and the effect accumulates. The platform amplifies whatever unit it is given. The unit decides everything.

The field's largest dataset agrees from another angle. Across 323 maximalist campaigns from 1900 to 2006, nonviolent campaigns succeeded 53% of the time against 26% for violent ones, and none failed after sustained active participation of 3.5% of the population (Chenoweth and Stephan). The sobering update: since 2010 the success rate of nonviolent campaigns has fallen below 34%, with participation depth declining decade on decade — the platform era made movements faster, larger, and shallower (Tufekci). Mass membership is the variable; the feed cannot supply it.

One caution against overclaiming: successes attract post-hoc method attribution. MADD's halving also owes to safer cars, seatbelt laws, demographics; the clean attribution evidence is the truth campaign's quasi-experimental 22%. Cite that one as proof; let the others stand as pattern.

And one convergence finding, stronger than any single case: the durational-membered-demonstrative combination emerged independently on at least four continents — Germany, Kenya, Argentina, South Africa, and the quilt in the United States — almost always in movements too poor to buy reach. That is convergent evolution. It suggests the combination is not a style but what advocacy becomes when it cannot afford to fail expensively.

One honest counter-case keeps the convergence claim from overreaching. Esperanto: more than a century durational, deeply membered, itself a working demonstration of its own claim — and it never tipped. Three commitments without a named blocking belief and an on-ramp the audience can actually afford (adoption cost, network effects) still lose. The combination recurs among winners; it does not guarantee winning — which is why the method in §7 carries four commitments, not three.

The psychology beneath the record

Sections 3–5 show that the pattern holds. Psychology explains why. Nearly every finding above sits on a named, experimentally studied mechanism — which converts the four commitments in §7 from design taste into mechanism-backed choices, and tells a campaign designer not just what worked, but what the mind was doing while it worked.

Why persuasion fails. Reactance (Brehm, 1966): people defend their freedom to conclude for themselves, and a message experienced as pressure produces push-back — up to the boomerang, where the audience moves the other way. D.A.R.E. was a reactance machine: authority instructing adolescents. The elaboration likelihood model (Petty and Cacioppo): change is durable only via the central route — the person generating the reasoning themselves — while received messages ride the peripheral route and fade with the campaign. Self-persuasion (Janis and King; Aronson): attitudes shift most when people articulate the case in their own words — which is what the listener does in deep canvassing, and what a viewer does in front of an uncaptioned demonstration. Motivated reasoning and identity-protective cognition (Kunda; Kahan): facts that threaten group identity are filtered before they can persuade; the much-cited backfire effect turns out to be rare (Wood and Porter), but corrections still underperform — the frame survives the fact-check. Persuasion is not merely weak; past a threshold of felt pressure it is counterproductive.

Why demonstration works. Mere exposure (Zajonc): repeated unforced encounter breeds familiarity and liking with no argument occurring — duration's quiet engine. Contact theory (Allport; Pettigrew and Tropp's meta-analysis across hundreds of studies): sustained contact reduces prejudice, and parasocial contact — mediated exposure to a real, particular person — carries a measurable share of the effect. This is why marriage equality moved when the abstract became a neighbour, and it is the mechanism of a revisited point: manufactured neighbourship at distance. Narrative transportation (Green and Brock): absorption in a story lowers counterarguing — the mind stops debating and starts inhabiting; a form with no narrator maximises this, because there is no claim to argue with. And the spacing effect, among the oldest findings in memory research: distributed exposure outlasts massed exposure. The revisit pulse is spaced repetition; the viral burst is massed practice — vivid, and gone.

Why membership works. Attitudes follow behaviour more reliably than behaviour follows attitudes. Cognitive dissonance (Festinger; the 1959 experiment in which one dollar changed minds and twenty dollars did not): a freely

chosen act restructures belief to match it, and the smaller the external justification, the deeper the shift. Foot-in-the-door (Freedman and Fraser): one small performed act — a stone sponsored, a tree planted, a bucket poured — makes the next act consistent with a new self-image. Effort and cost bind identity: the costliest signals — own money at risk, own name on a story — fuse members to movements; the diamond hand and the fella are costly-signalling badges. The token-support caveat (Kristofferson): cheap public gestures predict nothing further unless the act links to identity — which is precisely the difference between a share and a membership act, measured.

Why futility is the blocking state. The fear-appeal meta-analyses (Witte and Allen): fear moves people only when paired with believable efficacy — threat without a doable response produces denial, avoidance, and message rejection. That is Remain, Scared Straight, and the pity-to-futility hardening after Band Aid, in one model. Learned helplessness (Seligman and Maier): uncontrollability, demonstrated repeatedly, teaches a passivity that generalises beyond its source — and its documented treatment is demonstrated contingency, the experience that action produces effect. A growing thing, revisited, is demonstrated contingency in public. Compassion collapses at scale (Slovic; Västfjäll): one identifiable person moves us, and the numbing begins as early as the second — the single subject as the unit of encounter is not a style choice but a cognitive limit. Pseudoefficacy, from the same laboratory: the felt uselessness of helping one while millions suffer suppresses helping at all — which an on-ramp sized to one point is built to answer.

The adversary's psychology. The firehose is applied cognitive science. The illusory truth effect (Hasher): repetition alone raises judged truth — fluency masquerading as accuracy; volume is the weapon because repetition is. The continued influence effect (Lewandowsky): misinformation keeps shaping inference after correction — the correction economy loses by design. And manufactured uncontrollability — every channel contradicting every other — is a learned-helplessness protocol aimed at whole publics: the product is not belief but the certainty that nothing can be known and nothing done. §6's futility finding is this section's mechanisms, weaponised.

Two honesty notes. Psychology's own record includes replication failures; the mechanisms above are among the better-replicated, effect sizes vary, and the pattern evidence in §3–§5 stands independently of any one of them. And mechanisms are not a control panel: they say which way the grain runs, not that wood can be made to do anything.

Read back onto §7, the mapping is one line per commitment: duration works by exposure, contact, and spacing; membership works by dissonance, commitment, and costly signalling; demonstration works by reactance avoided and meaning self-generated; falsifiability is the designer's own debiasing — the only mechanism in this section aimed at the advocate rather than the audience.

Art, marketing, and the border between

Creative advocacy is the phrase under which much of this work is now commissioned, so the two great carriers deserve their own examination. The finding up front: neither art nor marketing is a method. Both are carriers — crafts of making meaning legible and portable — and like the platforms in §5, each amplifies whatever unit it is given. Art has carried memorials and tyrannies; marketing has carried truth and Kony

1. The unit decides; the carrier delivers.

What art does that argument cannot. Art is demonstration's native language. A made thing shows, and the viewer finishes — the no-narrator rule was an artistic principle long before it was an advocacy one. The psychology section explains the power: transportation lowers counterarguing; images reach emotion before deliberation; participation in making binds identity. The lineage of the advocacy image runs in a straight line: the Brookes diagram (1788); Lewis Hine's child-labour photographs — he forged nothing, talked his way into the mills, recorded names and ages, and the laws followed — and every war photograph since. Participatory art then institutionalised the audience's completion of meaning: Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed turned spectators into spect-actors who stop the scene and play the alternative themselves. Forum theatre is the audience completing the meaning, performed live — invented under a dictatorship and exported everywhere.

The measured limit of the iconic image. The strongest natural experiment in this document: Alan Kurdi, September

1. After the photograph circulated, daily donations to the

Swedish Red Cross Syria fund rose 100-fold — from under 1,000 a day to almost 14,000 — and the average daily amount raised was 55 times higher; the researchers found the newly created empathy waned rather quickly. But inside the decay, one number points the other way: signups for regular monthly donation rose ten-fold, and by the following January only 0.02% of those donors had cancelled. The image's burst behaved like every burst in §4 — and the people it converted into members stayed. One photograph, both halves of this document's thesis, measured.

Art's three failure modes. Aestheticisation: Sontag's warning that images of suffering, repeated, first shock and then anaesthetise — the beautiful photograph of the terrible thing becomes a way of not acting. Extraction: the subject as raw material for the artist's object — the war photographer's oldest wound, and one reason the membership commitment exists. And service: art is unit-agnostic. Socialist realism was art; superb craft has carried tyrannies' units before and will again. Craft guarantees nothing — the Guernica tapestry at the United Nations was covered over during the 2003 Iraq briefings precisely because everyone in the building knew what it argues.

Marketing: the discipline and the logic. Marketing entered advocacy formally in 1971, when Kotler and Zaltman named social marketing: the advertising toolkit — audience research, message testing, distinctive assets, disciplined consistency — applied to causes. The record splits along a line this document has drawn before. The discipline transfers: truth was marketing craft of the highest order — researched, tested, branded, measured — aimed at a demonstration unit, and it recouped its own cost. The logic does not: marketing's native logic is transactional — bought reach, quarterly horizon, the audience as consumers — and applied whole to advocacy it produces Kony 2012, which was slick-video marketing wearing a charity's name. Melbourne's Dumb Ways to Die marks the middle: charming craft, enormous organic reach, and an operator-claimed 21% drop in near-misses that independent analysts questioned — the virality was measured better than the behaviour.

Brand activism and the border. Brands now take stances, and the evidence says stances can sell: Nike's Kaepernick campaign drew boycott theatre and a 31% jump in online sales against 17% over the same days the prior year. Read it precisely: that is commerce aligning with its chosen customers' values — evidence that positions sell to segments, not evidence that advertisements change minds. The border case is Fearless Girl: a bronze of defiance facing the Wall Street bull, garlanded with the advertising industry's top awards — commissioned by an index fund to market a fund, by a firm that later settled claims of underpaying its own women. Art laundering commerce: every visual power of the medium, carrying a transaction. The inverse also exists: Patagonia's owner gave the company away to fund climate work — the brand-activism gesture done as demonstration rather than advertisement, an act no advertising budget could buy.

For makers. The synthesis: use art as the form and marketing as the craft, and let neither supply the unit. The strongest art-advocacy in the record — the quilt, the stones, forum theatre, participatory portrait projects — is art the audience or the shown people make themselves: the artwork is a membership act, not a picture of the cause. Make the thing people join, not the thing about them; test it like an advertiser, sign it like an artist, and give it away like neither.

6. The adversary's method — named, not emulated

The contemporary information environment is shaped by what RAND named the firehose of falsehood: high volume across many channels, rapid and continuous, no commitment to truth and none to consistency — with the aim not of persuading but of entertaining, confusing, and overwhelming. It is industrially funded; a single flagship outlet has carried a budget around \$300 million per year, before troll farms and proxy sites.

The critical reading: the firehose does not manufacture belief. It manufactures **futility** — the audience conclusion that truth is unknowable and engagement pointless. Much of what looks like Western fatigue is this method's intended product.

Read as design rather than as content, the firehose is a damping strategy. Incoherent volume across every channel raises the audience's internal friction until no signal can accumulate — manufactured futility is manufactured damping. Against a damping strategy, more volume is the wrong physics. The counter is coherence over time, the one thing that still accumulates when everything else is dissipated; §7 builds on this reading.

Its structural weakness: it can fake any single image and any single story, and it cannot fake **duration** — the same verifiable place, revisited, over years. A lie must be maintained; a garden only watered. Volume against volume loses. Time against volume is the asymmetric answer.

The firehose has also learned to buy rather than build. Influencer marketing grew from a \$1.7 billion niche in 2016 to about \$24 billion in 2024, projected toward \$32.5 billion in 2025 — an industry whose core commodity is parasocial trust, the audience's sense of knowing someone. The 2024 Tenet Media indictment proved that commodity is covertly purchasable by a state: about \$10 million moved through shell companies to one US content firm, roughly \$8.7 million of it to three commentators alone — one contract at \$400,000 per month — with a state employee editing content undisclosed. The adversary did not fight the creator economy; it bought shelf space in it. Hold the two price tags side by side: \$400,000 a month for one rented voice; 120 euros for one permanent stone.

The price-performance curve has since reached its logical end. In December 2024, Romania's Constitutional Court annulled the first round of its presidential election after declassified intelligence alleged a coordinated Russian campaign of thousands of TikTok and Telegram accounts promoting an outsider who had declared zero campaign spending and polled single digits before surging to first place — the first EU election voided over a platform influence operation, at a declared campaign cost of nothing. And the curve continues: synthetic generation is collapsing the cost of fabrication toward zero, which makes the scarce goods verification, provenance, and duration. The firehose's endgame is an environment where nothing is checkable. The durational answer is a small set of things that always are.

7. An alternative — a trimtab method

A note on the fit. This is one author's proposal, offered to be taken, renamed, or discarded. Funders' criteria for advocacy projects tend to ask the same four things — that outputs be built so hostile propaganda cannot turn them against the people shown; that nothing be faked; that the work not be a one-off action that fades in a week; and that it break through without a large advertising budget — and the method answers all four by construction: the capture-design

constraint, the no-fabricated-subjects rule, the duration commitment, and the trimtab. It dissents on one common instinct: it is slow where criteria prefer fast delivery — a dissent argued from the record in §4–§5, not from taste. On reach it does not dissent: most criteria offer targeted influence as an explicit alternative to mass reach, and the method takes that option and names it (the selectivity rule below). And it adds two things criteria rarely ask for: membership architecture for the people shown, and falsifiability beyond a stated theory of change. Any idea can be read against its funder's criteria this same way — that reading is part of the point of this section.

The trimtab. On a great ship, the rudder is too heavy for any force to push directly — so a small tab on the rudder's edge turns the rudder, and the rudder turns the ship (Fuller). The trimtab principle in advocacy: do not push the audience; place a small, well-designed thing where the medium's own flow does the moving. Carriers before crowds. Placement before volume.

The question. The method opens with *what if* — not an argument, a question. "What if this were possible?" A question cannot be rebutted, only answered; and the method answers it by building the thing and letting time verify it. What-if is the door out of the two comfort zones the field lives in: the audience's comfort of futility (nothing can be done, so nothing is asked of me) and the advocate's comfort of argument (being right is comfortable; showing and staying silent is not).

The model beneath the method — tuning, not transmission. The four commitments were read off the record. Beneath them sits a design model, set out at length in the companion case history on resonance (physics, metaphysics, sociology) and carried here only as far as its own transfer ledger allows. The field mostly broadcasts: a message at a frequency chosen for the sender's convenience, amplitude bought, decay per the ledger of episodic campaigns. The model reframes the task as tuning: find the receiver's frequency, place small inputs in phase, repeat coherently, and let the response build from the audience's own stored energy — its existing solidarity structures, memories, calendars, the concepts it already owns. The trimtab is this model stated as seamanship.

What the model borrows, and at what strength. As *mechanism*, measured in humans: bodies and groups entrain above a coupling threshold; synchronised action binds; spaced exposure outlasts massed exposure (already in the psychology section). As *structure* — the form of the physics without its mathematics: the response energy is the receiver's own, released by a matched input rather than injected by a large one; timing and placement beat force and volume; accumulation requires inputs in phase with each other, and incoherent repetition cancels; damping is always present and sets the ceiling; depth of response and breadth of audience trade off, and a claim to both at once is a claim to have repealed a theorem. As *ethic* — a convergence of traditions two millennia apart, adopted as commitment and not asserted as fact: the faked stimulus gets no response; response is invited by condition-making and never forced, and the attempt to force it produces its opposite; both parties change, or it was broadcasting with better manners.

What it does not borrow — and a hostile reader will check: people are not linear oscillators, and attitudes have no single clean frequency and no measurable phase; driven response between an advocate and a distant audience is analogy, not mechanism — only entrainment in co-presence is mechanism; no formula computes anything about an audience, and selectivity is a design choice here, never a number; and the model's vocabulary arrives pre-captured, by wellness commerce and by the demagogue's own self-description, so it governs design and never enters campaign language — the audience experiences the effect or nothing happened.

Four commitments, load-bearing together:

1. **Duration as evidence.** Publish only what can be revisited; schedule the revisit into the form. The return is the argument. This is also the direct counter to the firehose (§6).
2. **Membership, not extraction.** The person shown owns the showing. Consent names the reach and the permanence before anything publishes; belonging attaches to the contribution; withdrawal stays possible. Structure, not compliance.
3. **Demonstration, not persuasion.** No narrator, no ask, no concluding caption. The audience completes the meaning or nothing happens. Doors, never a hand on the back.
4. **Falsifiability in the room.** State predicted results in advance, including expected near-nulls on single exposure; run a hostile-read round that can remove content classes before they are built; name the failure conditions. A method that cannot say what would disprove it is a belief.

Any three without the fourth collapse into something the field already has: duration without membership is surveillance; membership without demonstration is a newsletter; demonstration without falsifiability is faith.

Three design rules the model adds, which the four commitments imply but do not state:

1. **Choose selectivity, and say which.** Depth and breadth trade off. A narrow, well-defined audience with a deep, accumulating response and a long after-effect is a legitimate and usually superior choice to broad reach with shallow response and fast decay. Carriers before crowds is the narrow choice: tune sharply to the few whose own coupling then carries the many. The choice is named per campaign, because it also chooses the measuring instrument (below); claiming both ends of the trade-off is self-deception.
1. **One drop point, in sequence.** Inputs out of phase with each other cancel, so the entry point is one and it is chosen: one point, one rhythm, proven or falsified, then the next. Two images hold the decision — the pebble into the pond, where the medium's own coupling carries the wave outward from a single entry, and the small hammer on the mountain, the same spot returned to blow after patient blow. Selection criteria: an existing oscillation (a rhythm

already running, not still water); strong coupling (a carrier whose own audience demonstrably follows them); low damping (the moveable middle — those neither hostile nor already convinced — not a band already saturated to futility); a return path (a medium that structurally supports revisit — a newsletter can, a feed cannot); survivable placement (consent, safety, and capture design travel with the input; a drop point that exposes anyone is disqualified whatever its coupling). Candidates for a first drop point, in any instance: the room in which the work is first shown; a single-carrier test with one listener in the chosen audience, the smallest possible pond; and a strand of that audience's solidarity infrastructure — twinnings, aid groups, congregational networks, teachers, newsletter writers. The choice is a named decision with a predicted response and a stated failure condition attached — the falsifiability commitment applied to placement itself.

1. **Feedback must be able to change the work.** Physics leaves the driver unmoved; every human register insists that both parties change or it was not response. Structurally: what comes back from the audience must be able to alter form, subjects, and schedule — or the method is transmission wearing better manners. Working with, not for, is the two-way condition stated as design.

The comfort-zone ledger. The method asks every party to trade a comfort, and it names the trades openly:

- The **advocate** trades control: no narrator means no final word; giving the idea to those it belongs to means no ownership; an empty region held empty until real consented material exists means patience over polish.
- The **audience** trades the spectator seat: the on-ramp (follow, twin, fund, visit) makes the next step theirs, and futility stops excusing them the moment one demonstrated counter-example exists.
- The **person shown** trades invisibility — only ever by their own named, informed, revocable step.

Design constraints that travel with the method:

- Every output built to survive hostile re-use; in doubt, unpublished.
- Classes of subjects whose exposure cannot be made safe are excluded by design — in wartime: children, precise places, schedules tied to named people. No gate opens this.
- No fabricated subjects, no composites; scaffolding always flagged as scaffolding.
- No trace more durable than the act requires; cryptography may touch artifacts, never people.
- The model is unit-agnostic and works for the wrecker: find a community's frequency and it is attackable through it with small force — a precise description of targeted disinformation, which tunes grievance rather than arguing anything. So no output hands an adversary a frequency map of the community shown: what moves them, when, through whom. And declining synchrony is sometimes the design — soldiers break step on a bridge.

Measurement. The falsifiability commitment requires instruments, and the model supplies them; all are stated before the first input.

- *Match the instrument to the chosen selectivity.* A campaign tuned to a narrow carrier band will not move a national poll, and expecting it to is a category error. Population polling measures the terrain; the campaign's own band is measured directly. Choosing selectivity chooses the instrument, and the choice is declared with the campaign.
- *Terrain instruments — polling that already exists.* Support series (Eurobarometer; national trackers), salience rankings, willingness-to-bear-cost items, and — closest to the blocking belief — futility proxies: expected war outcome, perceived efficacy of support. Read, never commissioned; they date quickly and are refreshed on the same discipline as any audience reading. A small project buys no polls.
- *Campaign instruments — four proxies read as curves.* Returns to the work are the return rate; follow retention after each pulse, plotted as a decay curve, is the after-effect; response to pulse N against pulse N–1 for the same cohort is accumulation; clustering of returns around the pulse schedule is entrainment. Nothing new is collected — follows per point, twinning inquiries, funds moved, and returns already carry all four quantities once read as curves rather than totals.
- *The baseline.* Before the first input: terrain figures at T-zero, campaign instruments at their zeros, and the predicted curves written down — including the predicted near-null on single exposure. Without the baseline there is no falsification, only narrative.
- *Benchmarks from the record, not invented.* The burst decay curve is the curve to beat: the platform-era spike and reversion (§5) and the measured waning after the iconic image (the art section). The retention benchmark is that same natural experiment's other half — monthly donors converted during the burst, of whom almost none cancelled. The durational growth benchmark is the stone count: three decades, one stone at a time, the price of a dinner per point.
- *Publish the nulls.* The deep-canvassing literature published its own failure — the 2014 study retracted, the 2016 replication that held — and came out stronger for it. Predicted, observed, and missed are all reported, or the falsifiability commitment is decoration.

A five-part test for whether something is an instance:

1. a real, revisitable subject;

2. an owner-member, not a source;
3. a form with no narrator;
4. a stated failure condition;
5. the audience's blocking belief named, not assumed.

The historical cases in §3 that pass most of this test — Stolpersteine, Green Belt, the Madres, TAC — were never designed from it; they converged on it. What this alternative adds is deliberateness: choosing in advance what poor movements discovered under constraint.

8. Honest limits

- The method is slow by design and loses every news cycle. It is wrong for crisis response and does not pretend otherwise.
 - Attribution is unsolved: no method in this document can prove the change it causes; this one at least states its failure conditions.
 - Scale is bounded by consent. Membership architecture does not compress; growth moves at the pace of real consent conversations. Accepted as a feature — it is also what makes the trust legible.
 - Under closed, repressive systems, demonstration meets force rather than counter-argument, and the cost lands on identifiable people. Any audience decision that raises personal risk is a deliberate, named decision — never drift.
 - The model's mechanism claims are bounded: entrainment is mechanism only in co-presence; at distance, everything in §7's model is structure and ethic, argued from convergence, not measured physics.
 - No phase can be measured. The method cannot compute its timing; it can only read the audience continuously and accept being wrong — which folds back into falsifiability: predicted response, observed response, stated failure condition.
 - Damping may win. Against sufficiently manufactured futility, coherence over time is the best available answer and still may not accumulate; the method cannot promise otherwise.
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9. An invitation

This document is offered under a share-alike licence on purpose. Take the taxonomy, the record, the method. Rename it. Improve it. Prove an instance in your own domain — the five-part test in §7 is the whole entry requirement. The method's own first rule applies to the method itself: it is demonstrated by use, not argued by its author.

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Further reading. There is no single science of advocacy; the research lives on five shelves that barely cite each other, and this document is one of the places they meet. The entries that most repay a participant's time:

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- Röttger, *PR-Kampagnen*, and Baringhorst's Siegen research — the standard German campaigns literature. Search

German scholarship under Bewegungsforschung, Interessenvertretung, and Kampagnenführung, not "advocacy", or you will wrongly conclude nothing exists.

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Provenance

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